



and Maytas Housing of Hyderabad and many real estate groups.

"It is sheer jealousy and prejudice which drives these media stories," says E.P. Jayarajan, general manager, *Deshabhimani* and also the chairman of Kannur's tourism co-operative which launched the Malabar Pleasures Private Ltd. He claims the *Deshabhimani* building was built with its own resources. "The party has to grow with the times and what is wrong in launching tourism projects which can provide jobs and entertainment to many young people?"

UNREAL ESTATE: (CLOCKWISE) PARTY HEADQUARTERS, KAIRALI/TV CHANNEL OFFICE, PARTY GUEST HOUSE AND THE NEW DESHABHIMANI BUILDING

In land-starved Kerala, the CPI(M) uses its might to seize public property.



for these brick and mortar marvels are contributions from the masses. It claims that its "bucket collections"—where cadres go around the state with requests for contributions—bring in crores in a few days. According to a senior leader, when party cadres had set out in 2001 to collect Rs 1 crore to set up the EMS Academy, they ended up collecting Rs 4 crore in three days. "It was a symbol of the respect and regard our party and its leaders like EMS Namboodiripad had among the masses," says Pinarayi Vijayan, CPI(M)

state secretary. But many say the party actually resorts to coercion and takes large donations from the very same rich and powerful that it reviles in public. Party leaders routinely go on fund collection tours to the Gulf where about three million Malayalees live. Vijayan was there recently for a month to raise funds for the Nayanar Memorial. Documents submitted by the CPI(M) to the Election Commission say its major donors in 2004-5 included, Subhash Chandra of Zee Telefilms

asks Jayarajan, a CPI(M) Central Committee member and Vijayan's close confidant. State Finance Minister Thomas Isaac says unlike other parties, funds collected by the CPI(M) go to the party coffers.

Such arguments are taken with a pinch of salt even by lower-level staff who are forced to survive on a pittance while the leadership leads jet-setting lives. "Had the huge amounts of money spent on the building been used to buy better equipment and pay the journalists higher salaries, *Deshabhimani* could have become a more popular paper. But the salaries of the party paper and the channel are about half of what other media organisations pay," says a journalist.

In office for the last year of its current term, the CPI(M)-led Left Democratic Front Government is accused of gifting away prime public property to trusts launched by the party in the name of departed leaders. The high court has even sent notice to the party-controlled municipal corporation in land-starved Kochi to explain such transfers of property for construction of memorials. One thing, however, is certain: the leaders after whom the memorials are being built will surely be turning in their graves. ■